

Impact of Social Media Trends on Impulsive Buying Behavior: A Gender-Based Study

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Abstract

The research scrutinizes the impact of social media trends on impulse buying behavior, primarily focusing on gender-specific differences among young consumers in Pune city, India. A structured questionnaire was distributed through Google Forms, which helped in collecting primary data from 38 respondents aged predominantly 18-24 years, consisting of 25 females and 13 males. In order to analyze the difference between the two genders' impulsive purchasing behavior, statistical tools, including T-tests, were employed.

According to the findings, though females tend to spend more time on social media platforms and follow influencers more than males, the difference in impulsive buying behavior is statistically not significant. The intensity of impulse buying is diminished, as both genders are conscious before purchasing products by comparing the reviews and prices, resulting in planned or rational buying. Additionally, males reported slightly higher social pressure to buy trendy products; the difference is not statistically significant. The study also notes that males are more influenced by celebrities as a type of influencer, and females are more influenced by macro-influencers.

The implications of the research reveal that marketers should not focus solely on gender but rather on engagement patterns and shopping channels. Seasonal discounts are found to be more effective in driving purchases than influencer promotions. Limitations include a very small, non-representative sample size and possible respondent bias. The study offers valuable insights for marketers to modify their campaigns responsibly in the evolving social media landscape.

Keywords: Social media trends, impulse buying behavior, social media influencers, social pressure.

I. Introduction

Background and Context

In today's rapidly evolving environment, Gen-Z is taking the lead in establishing new trends, particularly those influenced by social media representations. The act of creating social media accounts and sharing stylish photos along with various products has turned into a common practice. Furthermore, the greater accessibility and visibility across different social media platforms, including Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, X (formerly Twitter), Snapchat, and WhatsApp, have enhanced consumers' exposure to social media personalities. The influencers routinely endorse a variety of products, particularly in fashion, by creating reels or shorts on platforms like Instagram and YouTube, setting trends such as 'Get Ready With Me (GRWM)', and testing various items, including skincare and haircare products, as well as clothing from diverse online and offline stores. Social media users generally tend to follow these influencers and are noted for making impulse purchases. Consequently, it is essential to study this buying behavior, and it becomes particularly intriguing when such analyses are conducted based on gender, providing valuable insights for marketers to identify specific target audiences and avoid broad assumptions.

Research Problem and Objectives:

Impulse buying behavior is a frequently researched topic, leading to the development of marketing strategies that examine changing consumption patterns. However, conducting a gender-focused analysis in an urban setting like Pune could yield more fascinating insights into gender-specific impulse buying influenced by online trends. This study aims to investigate the differences in impulse buying among genders.

The objectives of this research paper are:

- a) To evaluate the degree of variation between males and females regarding impulse buying behavior.
- b) To study the reason behind impulsive purchases and the extent of ‘social pressure’ that impacts these choices in males and females.
- c) To understand whether the buying habits tend to be impulsive/unplanned or conscious/planned, taking into account factors such as reviewing products, waiting for sales, making purchasing decisions based on prices, and how these tendencies vary by gender.

Significance of the study.

Impulse buying driven by social media can have broad economic implications for businesses and consumer welfare. Conducting gender-based research, including various driving factors of impulsive consumer behavior in Pune city, such as the amount of time spent on social media, the impact of a particular type of social media influencer, differing preferences towards offline stores and online shopping platforms, and the urge to ‘fit in’, provides significant insight to the marketers. It will help them to identify whether males and females respond to social media trends differently and tailor their strategies more effectively, targeting consumers with relevant products and reducing market wastage. With young consumers spending substantial time on platforms such as Instagram, YouTube, and WhatsApp, deciphering the psychological triggers and social pressures influencing impulse buying helps in designing ethical, responsible campaigns.

II. Literature Review:

Impulse Buying

Impulse buying has become an important topic in consumer behavior research, especially with the rapid growth of online shopping. According to Nougara hiya, Shetty, & Mandloi (2021), increases in digital literacy, internet penetration, and the number of smartphone users in India have significantly driven the expansion of e-commerce over the past decade. This shift has resulted in changing consumption patterns, triggers for purchasing behavior, and marketing strategies. As a result of this evolution, impulsive purchases are increasing, often influenced by social media trends driven by influencers. While traditional buying is usually seen as a thoughtful and rational process where consumers assess the usefulness of products, impulse buying involves spontaneous and unplanned purchases made without prior reflection (Rook, 1987, cited in Prihana Gunawan & Permadi Iskandar, 2020). Loudon and Bitta (2016, cited in Lestari, 2020) describe it as an unconscious tendency to buy, further dividing it into four types: pure impulse, suggestion impulse, reminder impulse, and planned impulse. These categories demonstrate that impulse purchases can differ in consumer awareness, from sudden urges to buy, reminders of scarcity, or waiting for discounts and deals. Here, the ambiguity arises, whether such products are solely purchased impulsively or rational evaluation has a role to play (John et. Al, 2019, cited in Evangelin, Gokulakrishnan, & Sasikumar, 2023). In support of this, Evangelin (2021), as cited in Evangelin, Gokulakrishnan, & Sasikumar (2023), asserts that offline real stores that offer tangibility, especially while buying clothes, tend to make people buy more impulsively in contrast to online purchases.

Content Marketing / Social Media Marketing

With increasing numbers of social media users, marketers are compelled to advance themselves and use tools such as social media marketing to maximize their sales volume by creating attractive displays and activities to encourage impulsive buying (David S., in Mullin and friends, 2015, in Lestari, 2020). The digital brand content leads consumers to a purchase decision by building relationships, credibility, and trust (Wall & Spinuzzi, 2018), cited in (du Plessis, 2022). Instagram, a social media platform, has been the prime focus of many researchers. Reels with short duration tend to attract a significant amount of users by sharing photos and videos promoting products (Nisrina, 2015, in Triwidisari, Nurkhin, & Muhsin, 2017). However, such an impact may vary according to different consumer demographics and cultural contexts. Therefore, it can be stated that social media marketing may not uniformly create impulsive buying tendencies, but rather also interacts with trust, prior experience, and peer influence.

Fashion Influencers

A fashion influencer is a personality with a large number of followers on social media who creates primarily fashion content and has the power to influence the opinion and purchasing behavior of others with their recommendations (Prihana Gunawan & Permadi Iskandar, 2020). Based on the number of followers, influencers are classified as Nano-influencers (<1k, often friends and peers), micro-influencers (less than 100.000), macro-influencers (more than 100.000), and celebrities (Christodoulaki, 2018, and Barker, 2017, in Prihana Gunawan & Permadi Iskandar, 2020). The factors, such as reach and authenticity, vary across types of influencers. Accordingly, the endorsement from a specific influencer is sufficient for followers to assess the product's quality. This occurs due to the trust that has been established over time on social media platforms and with

influencers (Satriana, Rachmavati, & Alfianur, 2014) (Prihana Gunawan & Permadi Iskandar, 2020).

Gender Differences

Minimal research has been conducted on the significance of gender-based differences in impulsive buying behavior influenced by social media trends. Out of which, Gandhi (2020) claims that men appear to be more likely to engage in impulse buying than women. The author asserts that these findings are supported by Parmar Vishnu and Ahmed Rizwan Raheem in their study, which indicates that the ratio of male to female in impulse buying stands at approximately 3:1. These findings clearly stand against the generalized notion that women are more susceptible to impulsive purchases than men. However, the validity of data may vary depending on various factors; thus, such comparisons should not be seen as universal.

Gaps Identified

A population gap and geographical gap have been identified as the referred researches (Satriana, Rachmavati, & Alfianur, 2014), (Prihana Gunawan & Permadi Iskandar, 2020), (Lestari, 2020), (Triwidisari, Nurkhin, & Muhsin, 2017) were conducted in Indonesia, and (Gandhi, 2020) and (Evangelin, Gokulakrishnan, & Sasikumar, 2023) were conducted in Mumbai and Chennai, respectively. This research study has taken place in Pune city, which assists in identifying how the buying behaviors of people in Pune differ from other locations. A significant research gap that is of prime focus is the gender-based study on impulsive purchases. It will be interesting to revisit the findings of previous researchers like Gandhi (2020), who claimed that men are more predominant shoppers compared to women, which presents a contrasting perspective.

III. Research Methodology

Research Design and Approach:

This study adopts a quantitative, descriptive, and comparative research design. The focus of this research is to examine the impact of social media trends on impulse buying behavior, with a particular emphasis on identifying gender-based differences. A structured questionnaire was used to measure attitudes and behaviors, comprising seven questions based on a Likert scale that provided numerical data for statistical analysis. The comparative aspect is crucial in recognizing the differences between the responses of males and females.

Data Collection Methods:

Primary data collection is an integral part of this research study. An online questionnaire was distributed via Google Forms, consisting of 23 questions, including several closed-ended, demographics-related inquiries, attitude towards social media platforms and influencers, shopping habits, and one short open-ended question. Seven questions were based on a five-point Likert scale ranging from “Strongly Disagree (1)” to “Strongly Agree (5)” for detecting behavioral insights. For easy accessibility, this form was circulated on social media platforms such as WhatsApp and LinkedIn. It was filled mainly by friends and family members. A total of 38 responses were collected, comprising 25 females and 13 males. The time period for which the form was circulated was one week; after that, responses were no longer accepted. The majority of the audience belongs to the age group of 18-24 years, among whom a few are employed and others are students pursuing higher education. This age group has significant social media usage, which provides perhaps better insights for this study. While considering time constraints, convenience, and the need for better responses, this method of data collection was preferred. The sample questionnaire used for this study has been attached to this paper after references.

Secondary data, collected from the referenced research studies, have been used to compare the findings derived from primary data.

Data Analysis:

The collected data was compiled, structured, and processed. Statistical tools such as mean, variance, and T-test, have been performed using Microsoft Excel to derive valid inferences. Data collected using a Likert scale was used to perform a T-test, which helped to analyze gender specific differences in impulsive buying and factors driving such impulses. Such results are represented in a table format for visible analysis. Bar charts and pie charts are used to compare responses of females and males on aspects such as impulsive buying destinations, type of social influencers followed the most, and amount of time spent on social media platforms. The null hypothesis and the alternative hypothesis have been set up, based on which any possible significant differences between male and female impulsive purchasing behavior have been analyzed. In the end of the questionnaire, a short-length open ended question was asked to the respondents for qualitative purpose.

IV. Results

Data Presentation and Findings (Source: Primary Data)

The null hypothesis (H_0) and the alternative hypothesis (H_a) have been set up with a confidence level of 95% and a significance level of 5%. Therefore, the value p is 0.05. During the tests, if $p > 0.05$, then H_0 cannot be rejected, and if $p \leq 0.05$, H_a can be accepted.

Here,

H_0 = There is no significant difference between males and females in impulsive buying behavior.

H_a = There is a significant difference between males and females in impulsive buying behavior.

[Likert scale was used for collecting the following numerical data, ranging from ‘strongly disagree’ (1) to ‘strongly agree’ (5), and a T-test has been performed on each question.]

Table 1: Q1-Buying products spontaneously after seeing them on social media.

	Female	Male
Mean	1.88	2.38
Variance	0.78	1.59
Observations	25	13
t Stat	-1.29	
p-value (two-tailed)	0.21	

The average impulse buying score after seeing products on social media was slightly higher among male respondents (2.38) than female respondents (1.88), but this difference was not statistically significant ($p=0.21 > 0.05$). Thus, gender does not appear to have a significant impact on impulse buying behavior for this question. Also, the calculated low mean denotes that the respondents, in general, don’t buy products impulsively after seeing them on social media.

Table 2: Q2 - I have purchased items to "fit in" with trends promoted by influencers.

	Female	Male
Mean	1.72	2
Variance	1.293	1.333
Observation	25	13
t Stat	-0.713	
p-value (two-tailed)	0.482	

Again, the average score of items purchased to fit in is very slightly higher in males than in females, as shown in Table 2; thus, the difference is not statistically significant ($p>0.05$). According to the mean derived in Table 2, it can be identified that the respondents mostly reject any tendency to buy products to fit in to follow the trendsetters.

Table 3: Q3- I sometimes regret purchases I made after being influenced by social media trends.

	Female	Male
Mean	2.4	2.384
Variance	1.66	2.256
Observation	25	13
t Stat	0.033	
p-value (two-tailed)	0.974	

The average score of the feeling of regret after purchases made is influenced by social media trends, and is minimally higher in females than in males, as shown in Table 3. After performing a T-test, it is found that the difference is not statistically significant ($p > 0.05$). As per the mean derived in Table 3, it is found that the respondents, after making purchases influenced by social media trends, regret less than moderate level.

Table 4: Q4 - I usually compare reviews or prices before buying a product I saw online.

	Female	Male
Mean	4.4	4
Variance	1.1666	1.666
Observation	25	13
t Stat	0.9565	
p-value (two-tailed)	0.35	

The average score of online conscious buying is slightly higher in females than in males, but the difference is not statistically significant enough to conclude gender-specific differences ($p > 0.05$). On the other hand, according to the mean derived in Table 4, it can be observed that both female and male respondents buy online products consciously by comparing reviews and prices.

Table 5: Q5 – Discount codes or offers shared by influencers make me more likely to buy.

	Female	Male
Mean	2.16	2.923
Variance	1.64	2.077
Observation	25	13
t Stat	-1.607	
p-value (two-tailed)	0.1222	

The average score of impulsive buying driven by discount codes shared by influencers is slightly higher in males than in females, but the difference is not statistically significant ($p > 0.05$). In Table 5, the mean derived shows that the respondents are less than moderately likely to buy because of discount codes shared by influencers.

Table 6: Q6 – I wait for seasonal discounts to buy products.

	Female	Male
Mean	3.48	4.077
Variance	1.676	0.577
Observation	25	13
t Stat	-1.788	
p-value (two-tailed)	0.0824	

In the above table, the average score of purchases driven by seasonal discounts is slightly higher in males than in females, but the T-test asserts that the difference is not statistically significant ($p > 0.05$). When observing the mean derived, it can be noted that seasonal discounts influence both genders of respondents' purchasing behavior.

Table 7: Q7 – I feel social pressure to buy products that are trending on social media

	Female	Male
Mean	1.44	2.077
Variance	0.59	1.077
Observation	25	13

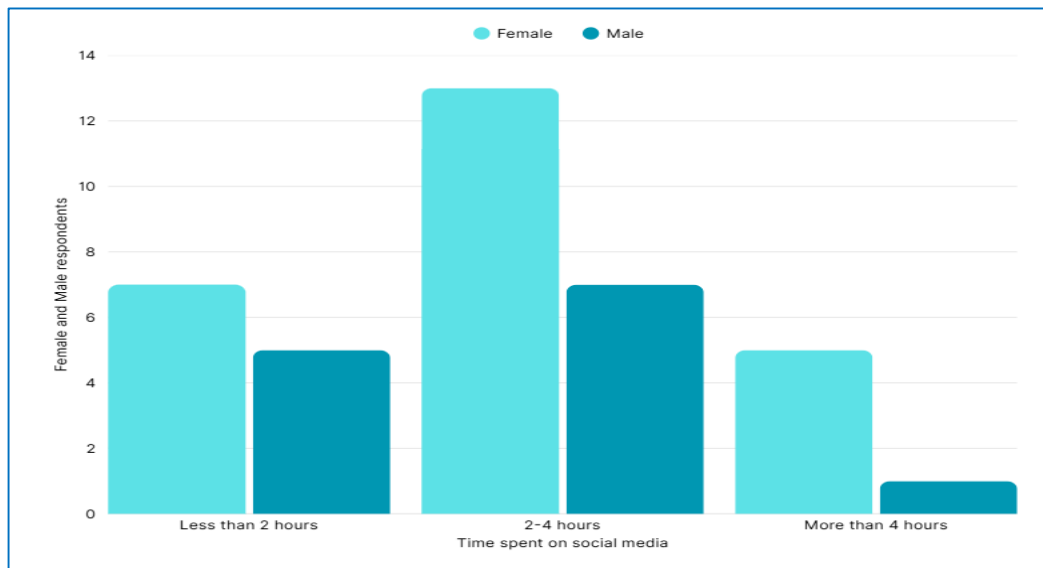
t Stat	-1.9522	
p-value (two-tailed)	0.0658	

The average score of social pressure experienced to buy a trending product is higher in males than in females, though the p-value derived is very close to 0.05, the derived value 0.0658 is not sufficient to identify a significant statistical difference between the two genders.

Therefore, considering the T-tests performed for all seven Likert scale-based questions, it can be concluded that there is no significant difference detected in impulsive buying behaviors of both females and males. However, by observing the results derived for Q7, it can be seen that males experience more social pressure to follow trends than females, although the difference is not statistically significant.

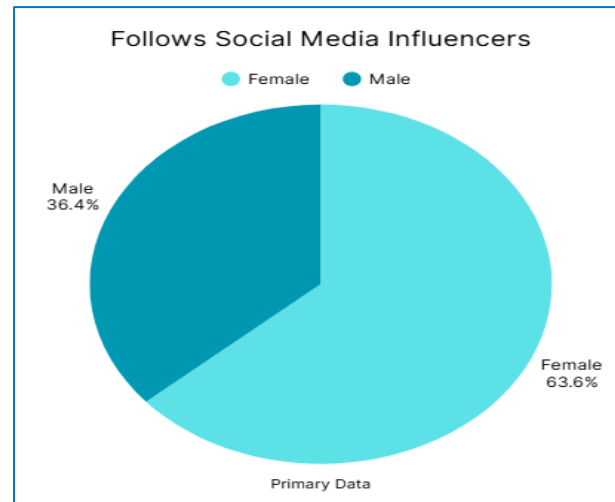
Descriptive Statistics: (Source: Primary Data)

Chart 1:



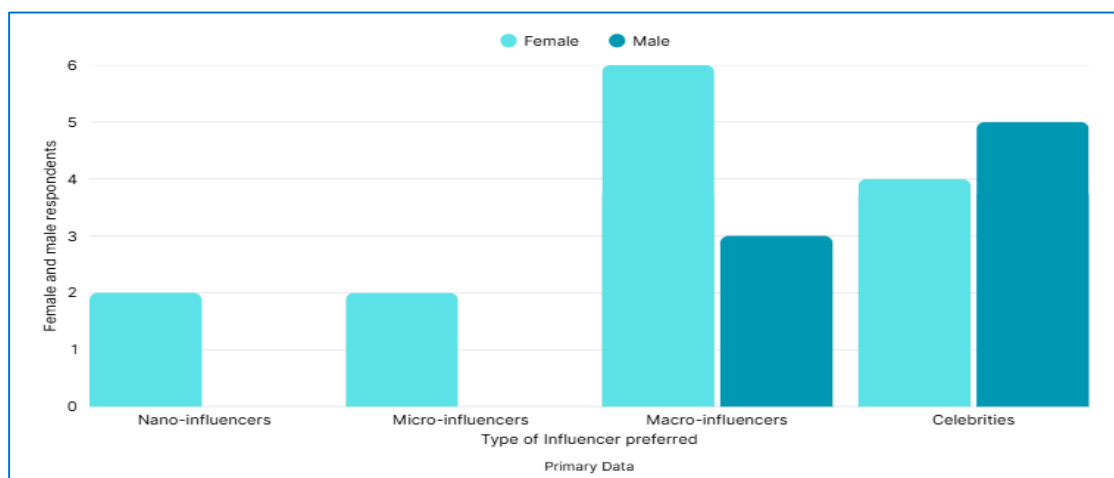
As observed in Chart 1, time spent on social media by females is higher than males, and both genders spend 2-4 hours on social media daily in maximum numbers.

Chart 2:



The Chart 2 represents the percentage of males and females who follow social media influencers. It can be seen that the percentage of females is higher than males.

Chart 3:



The above chart represents the influencer type preferred by males and females. It can be noted that females are more influenced by macro influencers who have more than 100,000 followers, while males are more influenced by celebrities. This shows a gender difference in trust-building with influencers. However, this finding contradicts with findings of Prihana Gunawan & Permadi Iskandar (2020) and Satriana, Rachmavati, & Alfianur (2014), that nano-influencers and

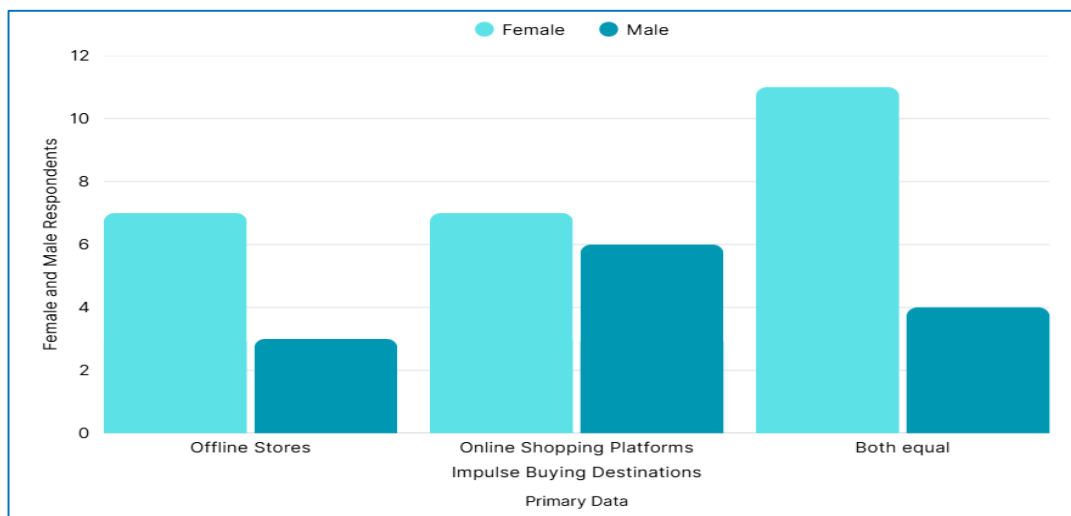
micro-influencers appear to be more accessible and trustworthy than macro-influencers and celebrities.

Chart 4:



In Chart 4, it can be observed as per the concentration of male and female data in different bars that females are less likely to buy a product seen on social media than males. This finding confirms the T-test finding of Q1.

Chart 5:



As per the data presented in Chart 5, it can be noted that females feel impulsive to buy products in offline stores as well as on online shopping websites, against males who find online shopping more impulsive.

V. Implications and Conclusions

Interpretation of Results

The study's findings majorly differ from the earlier findings. Female respondents spend more time on social media and follow influencers as compared to male respondents. This implies that females tend to engage more with trend-driven social media platforms. However, when the purchasing behavior influenced by social media is analyzed, the statistical analysis shows no significant difference in impulsive buying between females and males. The findings also show that social media influencers have less impact on impulse buying in both genders. Planned and rational purchases are made by females and males by comparing prices and reviews before buying, which cancels out the intensity of possible impulse buying, which is also supported by the short open-ended question asked during the survey. The respondents also report the feeling of regret after making social media-influenced purchases, less than moderate level. More importantly, male respondents reported the feeling of social pressure slightly more than female respondents to buy trendy products and to be more impulsive when shopping online, which resonates with the findings of Gandhi (2020), but these differences are not statistically significant. Additionally, male respondents are more influenced by celebrities, while female respondents are more influenced by macro-influencers, but these reported preferences do not significantly affect overall impulse buying behavior.

Implications

As the results show that impulsive buying behavior across genders is similar, marketing efforts to drive impulse purchase should not focus on targeting one specific gender; rather, the focus can be diverted towards specific engagement patterns and shopping channels. Other than the mentioned data in the findings section, during the survey, it was observed that both genders prefer Instagram and YouTube as social media platforms. Here, marketers can choose these platforms to promote their products and increase their consumer base. According to the results, both genders practice conscious buying, which implies that trend-based or influencer-driven promotions don't encourage impulse buying effectively; but seasonal discounts such as 'The Great Indian Festival Sale' or 'Freedom Sale' tend to attract both genders to purchase products. Therefore, marketers should aim for trust-building through improving the quality of their products, maintaining it to drive more positive reviews and aim for sales maximization during seasonal discounts, in order to widen the consumer base.

Limitations

As the findings of this study contradict the secondary data referred to in the referenced papers, it has several limitations. The most significant limitation is the sample size of the survey conducted, in which the number of male respondents is substantially smaller than that of female respondents, which may affect the representativeness of the statistical comparison. The overall sample size being 38, and the dominant 18-24 age group surely doesn't represent the population residing in Pune city, which reflects the sampling error of convenience bias. The study is limited to a very short time duration, which doesn't allow it to reflect changes or evolving trends. While analyzing the data collected, the Hawthorne effect was detected, which implies that the respondents tend to alter their behavior or responses in the survey as they were aware of being studied.

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Sample Questionnaire used to collect primary data

Title: Impact of Social Media Trends on Impulse Buying Behaviour: A Gender-Based Study in Pune.

Section A: Demographics

Your Name

Short answer

Age

Multiple choice: 5 options

Gender

Multiple choice: 4 options

Employment Status

Multiple choice: 5 options

Marital Status

Multiple choice: 3 options

Section B: Social Media Usage & Influencers

Which social media platforms do you use the most?

Checkboxes: 6 options

How much time do you spend daily on social media?

Multiple choice: 3 options

Do you follow social media influencers?

Multiple choice: 2 options

If yes, which type influences you the most?

Multiple choice: 5 options

Section C: Shopping Habits

Have you purchased a product because you saw it on social media?

Multiple choice: 4 options

Which type of products do you usually buy impulsively after seeing them online?

Checkboxes: 6 options

Where do you feel more impulsive to buy?

Multiple choice: 3 options

Preferred payment method for such purchases:

Multiple choice: 5 options

Section D: Behavioural Insights

I often buy products spontaneously after seeing them on social media.

Linear scale

I have purchased items to "fit in" with trends promoted by influencers.

Linear scale

I sometimes regret purchases I made after being influenced by social media trends.

Linear scale

I usually compare reviews or prices before buying a product I saw online.

Linear scale

Discount codes or offers shared by influencers make me more likely to buy.

Linear scale

I wait for seasonal discounts (for e.g. Great Indian Festival / Freedom Sale, etc.) to buy products.

Linear scale

I feel social pressure to buy products that are trending on social media.

Linear scale

Section E: Account & Purchase Behaviour

Do you ever use someone else's account (family/friend/partner) to make purchases influenced by social media?

Multiple choice: 4 options

If yes, whose account do you use most?

Multiple choice: 5 options

Section F: Reflection

In one sentence, describe why you usually buy products you see on social media.

Short answer
